

The Best Advice I Ever Got

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Moelis & Company is a leading global independent investment bank headquartered in New York



‘Go all out even if the odds are against you’

What was the problem you were grappling with?

When I started my career there were very few women in banking. When I went into meetings, people would not shake my hand or make eye contact. They would look at the male colleagues on my team instead, making me feel like I was talking to the wall. I often stopped my discussion midway and redirected the conversation back to my male colleagues, worried that we would not be taken credibly if I were seen as the lead banker from our end.

Who did you approach and why?

I asked my father, a career banker, for advice. He said the men I was meeting in the corporate world were facing a paradigm shift. They were not used to discussing finance and strategy with women and hence were struggling to take a woman's advice seriously on issues which, in their mind, were masculine.

What was the advice you received?

He advised me that I should not accede to the norm. The men will listen intently if my ideas were interesting, he said. Traditional patriarchal norms were not going to change overnight and if I wanted to be part of the change, I needed to stay the course, be resilient, work hard and eventually I would win over the clients with my authenticity, hard work and by demonstrating an understanding of their business. “Always make a total effort,” he said, “even when the odds are entirely against you”.

How effective was it in resolving the problem?

It worked out well. I have drawn on his advice about persistence and hard work throughout my career and credit it with helping me rise into leadership roles at global banks. **BT**

—KRISHNA GOPALAN

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